SALES MANAGER ESSENTIALS

Sales Manager Essentials — Day 5: Sales Reviews, Reporting, and Sustainable Growth

Study guide · Self-study

Day 5: Sales Reviews, Reporting, and Sustainable Growth

How to Use This Guide

This is the last day of Sales Manager Essentials. You have spent four days building the parts of the job: direction, targets, numbers and coaching. Today you put them together and make them run on a rhythm.

Read the explanations. Do the exercises. Write your answers before you look at the model answers at the end. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

This guide is a practice layer, not a textbook. Keep a notebook next to you. Write in it as you go. The reflection prompts and the What Would You Say? exercises are where the learning happens.

One habit to build before you start. Every exercise here uses your real pipeline, your real accounts and your real conversations. If you are between review cycles, open your last one and work from it. No sales manager role yet? Use a sales team you know well, such as a past employer.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the difference between a review meeting that produces decisions and one that produces recaps, and you will know the four things every honest forecast report must contain.

Attitude: You will treat the sales review as a decision forum, not a performance report card, and treat the forecast as your word to leadership, not a hopeful target in disguise.

Skill: You will be able to run a sales review meeting that ends with tracked commitments, and prepare a concise performance review that states the number, the confidence, the assumptions and what would change the outcome.

Upskill: You will lead a 30-day improvement plan from diagnosis to closure, coordinating with adjacent functions and evaluating whether the actions actually worked.

Sales Review Meetings That Produce Decisions

Most sales reviews fail for one reason. They recap what happened instead of deciding what happens next.

Think about the meeting you have sat through most often. The numbers go up on a screen. Each rep explains their month. Everyone nods. The meeting ends. Nobody leaves with a decision. That is a recap, and it costs you the one hour a week when your team could be solving problems together.

A decision-producing review looks different. It is short. It is structured. Every item ends with a decision, an owner and a date. The energy is forward-looking.

Why does this matter to the people in the room? A recap rewards the act of reporting. A decision forum rewards the act of thinking. Most salespeople would rather solve a customer problem than justify a number. When you run a decision forum, you are giving them the part of the job they are good at.

Here is the structure that works. Use it every cycle.

Open with the one number that matters most this week: pipeline coverage, conversion, or whatever the first priority in your current plan is. Not twelve numbers. One.

Then run the items that need a decision, not the items that need a report. A stalled deal, a slipping account, a territory that is not converting. For each item, ask three questions: what happened, what are we going to do, and who owns it by when.

Close by reading out the commitments made in the meeting, so each owner hears their own name and their own date.

What happens inside the meeting matters as much as the agenda. When a rep brings a problem, use SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact): the specific situation, the observable behavior, and its impact. You learned it on Day 4. One line reminder: describe what happened, not who they are.

On a real review, SBI keeps the conversation on facts and stops it turning into a debate about character. "In the last two weeks, the top ten deals all moved to next month. The pipeline looks healthy but nothing closes." That is SBI. It gives the team something to solve.

> **NOTES**
>
> Watch for the meeting that drifts into status updates. When you hear "so the customer said..." without a decision attached, redirect: "What are we deciding on this one today?"

Tracking Priorities and Closing the Loop

A commitment recorded in a review meeting is worth nothing unless someone checks it at the next one.

This sounds obvious. In practice, most reviews start from scratch. The commitments from last week are forgotten. The team learns that what you ask in the meeting is optional. That is a habit, and it is yours to break.

Build a simple tracker. Four columns are enough: the commitment, the owner, the date due, and the status. Keep it in front of you. Open the next review with it, before anything else. "Last week we agreed that the two stalled accounts would have a next step by Friday. Where are we?"

Why this works psychologically: commitments made in front of peers carry social weight. When people know their name will be read out at the next meeting, they treat the commitment as real. This is the principle of commitment and consistency described in Cialdini's work. Once a person has stated a commitment out loud, they feel pressure to act consistently with it. You are not applying pressure. You are simply giving the commitment a place to live.

The second half of the loop is evaluating whether the action worked. This is the part most managers skip. You agreed an action. The rep did it. Did the outcome change? If not, why not? Was the action the right one, or did you fix the wrong problem?

That question is the difference between a manager who acts and a manager who learns. Every review should ask it about at least one prior action. "We agreed the rep would call the decision-maker directly. They did. The deal still stalled. So the blocker was not access. What was it?"

> **NOTES**
>
> Track one commitment per person, not five. Five commitments per person means none of them will happen. One per person, checked every cycle, builds the habit.

Reporting to Leadership with Honest Numbers

Your forecast is your word to your leadership. A forecast that is never wrong because it is always fuzzy is not a forecast. It is a wish.

Every honest report contains four things. State the number. State your confidence in it. State the assumptions behind it. State what would change the outcome. Four sentences, in that order.

The number. "We will close at the level of the current committed pipeline, plus a named share of the best-case pipeline." Say the number.

The confidence. "We are highly confident on the committed portion and less confident on the best-case portion." Say the level.

The assumptions. "This assumes the two large deals close on their current dates, and it assumes no new slippage on the mid-stage accounts." Say them out loud.

What would change the outcome. "If either of the two large deals slips by more than two weeks, the number drops by the value of that deal." Say the trigger.

Why does this matter to leadership? Senior leaders are not impressed by confident numbers. They are paid to manage uncertainty. A report that names its own risk is easier to act on than one that pretends there is none. When you give leadership your assumptions, you are not weakening the number. You are giving them something they can plan around.

There is a deeper reason. When you report a risk early and it lands, you look prepared. When you hide a risk and it lands, you look unreliable, even if the number was the same. People remember the surprise, not the figure.

The hardest thing to say to leadership is "I don't know." Say it anyway. Then say what you are doing to find out, and by when. "I don't know whether the strategic account will close this quarter. We will have a clear answer by the last Friday of the month." That is an honest report. It is not the same as a weak one.

> **NOTES**
>
> Never pad your confidence to sound decisive. A forecast you have to walk back next week costs more trust than a cautious one you beat.

Prioritizing Improvement Initiatives by Impact

You cannot improve everything at once. You need to choose the two or three actions that will move the number most.

This is where most improvement plans fail. A manager lists twelve things the team should get better at. The team nods. Then everyone goes back to doing what they were doing. Twelve priorities is the same as no priority.

Sort the candidate actions by expected impact. Two questions for each one. How much of the outcome gap would this close if it worked? How confident are you that it will work? Multiply those two in your head, roughly. The action with the largest product goes first.

Expected impact = (share of gap addressed) x (confidence it works).

Notice that confidence counts. A high-impact action you are 20% sure of is worth less than a modest action you are 80% sure of. Sales managers love the dramatic fix. The evidence says the modest, confident fix does more work.

Then go one level deeper. For each action, name the measure. If the action is "improve discovery quality on mid-stage deals," the measure is not "better discovery." The measure is something specific and observable, such as the share of mid-stage deals that reach a decision-maker before proposal. Write it down before you start.

Finally, coordinate. Most sales priorities touch another function. A discount discipline problem touches finance. A delivery problem touches operations. A lead quality problem touches marketing. Name the person in the adjacent function you need to involve, and tell them before the plan starts, not after it fails.

> **NOTES**
>
> Rank actions by impact, but check them against capacity first. If your team cannot run three actions in the next 30 days, run one. One action fully done beats three abandoned.

Apply It in Your Role

You are going to practice all of this in a 30-day plan. The plan should fit on one page. It has five parts.

The priority. One sentence. The one improvement in the next 30 days, connected to the sales number it moves.

The actions. Two or three specific actions that support the priority. Each one starts with a verb: coach, review, restructure, coordinate.

The measures. For each action, one measure you can see in the data or in the room.

The responsibilities. A name against each action, including yours.

The review dates. When you will check whether it worked. Put the date in your calendar now, not later.

Keep it short. A plan your team can read in two minutes is a plan they will use.

Now a note on how you use the plan in the review. The plan becomes the agenda. Each week, the review opens with the tracker and the plan measures. Not a fresh list of what everyone did. The same plan, checked again.

No sales manager role yet? Build the plan for a sales team you know well, such as a past employer.

What Would You Say?

Write your own answer to each situation before you look at the model answers.

1. Your team's best rep gives you a forecast that says "confident." You have watched this rep miss twice this quarter. What do you say in the review?

2. In your weekly review, a rep describes a deal in detail for four minutes. The deal has not moved in three weeks. No decision is on the table. What do you say?

3. Your regional leader asks for a forecast for next quarter. You have committed pipeline for the first half of the quarter and best-case for the second half. What do you report?

Key Takeaways

- A sales review produces decisions, not recaps. Every item ends with a decision, an owner and a date.
- Open each review with your tracker. Commitments read out loud get done.
- Close the loop on prior actions. Ask whether the action worked, not just whether it happened.
- Every honest forecast report has four parts: the number, the confidence, the assumptions and what would change the outcome.
- "I don't know" followed by a plan to find out is an honest report, not a weak one.
- Prioritize improvement by expected impact, adjusted for confidence, and coordinate the adjacent function before you start.
- One action fully done beats three half-started.

Quiz

Answer the five questions below. Then check the answer key.

1. Your weekly sales review is running thirty minutes late. What should you add to the agenda to make it produce decisions?

   A. A round of status updates from each rep
   B. A tracker of prior commitments and a decision, owner and date for each open item
   C. A longer list of every deal in the pipeline
   D. A recap of the team's best wins since the last review

2. Which four elements belong in every honest forecast report to leadership?

   A. The number, the confidence, the assumptions and what would change the outcome
   B. The number, the team's effort, the historical average and the upside
   C. The number, the risks, the competitor comparison and the target
   D. The number, the win rate, the activity count and the trend line

3. A rep keeps losing mid-stage deals to silence. You list three possible improvement actions. How do you choose which one to run first?

   A. The highest impact action, regardless of confidence

   B. The easiest action to run, so the team has a quick win

   C. The action with the largest expected impact, calculated by the share of gap addressed times the confidence it will work

   D. The action the rep personally prefers

4. In the review, a rep brings you a deal that has not moved in three weeks. What should you do first?

   A. Ask for a recap of the customer's history

   B. Ask the rep to update the CRM and move on

   C. Use SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) to describe the pattern, then ask what decision the team is making

   D. Take the rep off the account

5. Your regional leader asks for next quarter's forecast. You have committed pipeline and some best-case. What do you say?

   A. "We will hit target." Confident numbers are what leaders want

   B. "Here is the number, our confidence in each portion, the assumptions behind it and what would change it"

   C. "We will have to wait and see"

   D. "Give me a moment, I will pad it a bit to be safe"

Upskill Challenge

This challenge runs over the next 30 days. You will do it in your own job, on your own pipeline and your own team.

Step 1. Prepare a concise sales performance review. Take your last full cycle and write a one-page review. State the number, your confidence, the assumptions and what would change the outcome. This is for leadership, not for the team.

Step 2. Build the 30-day plan. Choose one improvement priority. Two or three actions. A measure for each. A name against each. A review date for each.

Step 3. Coordinate the adjacent function. Name the person in the adjacent function you need to involve, and set a short time to walk them through the plan before it starts.

Step 4. Run two review meetings. Open each with the tracker. Every item ends with a decision, an owner and a date.

Step 5. Close the loop. On day 30, look at the plan. Did the action happen? Did the measure move? If the action happened and the measure did not move, what does that tell you? Write the answer in your notebook.

No team yet? Do Steps 1, 2, 3 and 5 for a sales team you know well, and replace Step 4 with two practice reviews where a friend plays the rep.

This is the moment a sales manager turns a plan into a learning cycle. You are not looking for a clean result. You are looking for the reason a result happened.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. What matters is the principle behind each answer. Your words should sound like you.

1. "I have seen this rep miss twice this quarter. The principle: a forecast without assumptions is a wish. I would say: 'You have given me a confident number, and your last two forecasts slipped. Before I report it, let's walk through what has to be true for it to land. Which deals are you most confident in? What would have to happen for one of them to slip by two weeks?' That names the past misses without accusing, and moves the conversation to the assumptions. The rep's confidence is tested, not their character."

Why it works: the past misses are a pattern, not a verdict. Naming the pattern gently and asking about the assumptions gives the rep ownership of the risk in the number.

2. "The deal has not moved in three weeks. The principle: a review produces decisions. I would use SBI to name what I see, then ask what decision the team is making today. 'The customer is silent and we have not heard from them in three weeks. What are we deciding? Is it a next step, a different contact, or moving it out of the quarter?' That turns the recap into a decision."

Why it works: the rep's detail is not wasted; it is redirected. The question asks for a decision, which is the only thing that should happen in a review.

3. "Here is the number, our confidence in each portion, the assumptions behind it and what would change the outcome. The committed pipeline is the number we will hold ourselves to. The best-case portion is upside with lower confidence. The assumptions are the deal dates and the no-slippage condition. What would change it is a slip on either of the two large deals, which would drop the number by that deal's value."

Why it works: this report gives leadership a number they can plan around and a risk they can act on. It is honest, and it protects your credibility if the risk lands.

Quiz answers:

1. B. A decision forum needs a tracker and a named decision, owner and date for each open item.

2. A. The four-part report is the number, the confidence, the assumptions and what would change the outcome.

3. C. Expected impact is the share of gap addressed times the confidence it will work. Confidence counts.

4. C. Describe the specific situation, behavior and impact, then move the conversation to a decision.

5. B. Say the number, the confidence, the assumptions and the trigger, in that order. Padding and waiting are both dishonest.

References

- Cialdini, R. B. (2021). Influence, New and Expanded: The Psychology of Persuasion. Harper Business.
- Center for Creative Leadership (CCL). SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact).